



Model: SADA JOSHI, ELITE MODEL MANAGEMENT. Contents: ESPRIMO, LONDON: AQUA, THE PARK, NEW DELHI. Make up and hair styling: BILKA LUTPO, PHOTOS BY BANDEEP SINGH

History leads to hysteresis—the past tends to trap us; it resists change. Power networks tend to give opportunities to their own kind. A small number of women in power limit the opportunities for other women. Women are seriously under-represented in national and local assemblies. In Parliament, for example, they occupy only 10 per cent of the seats.

Economists had expected that industrialisation would put an end to women being treated as beasts of burden—they were to become rational, objective, competitive and efficient like men. But modernisation ignored women's choices and biological constraints, inadvertently contributing to a subtle devaluation of their work. The third wave of development—showing signs of uplifting women—makes it imperative for both sexes to share the so-called male and female values, with men contributing more to nurturing the home than they have done before and women becoming more active outside the home. But for this to happen the softer qualities that have in the past been associated with women have to be valued more widely.

Valuing their special qualities is perhaps necessary for social survival. The 2001 Census shows an alarming fall in the sex ratio, especially in the 0-6 age group—from 875 females per 1,000 males in 1991, the number fell

Only **16%** of urban Indian women work for a living, but only a quarter have control over their earnings

66.33% of women from urban India prefer to work rather than keep house

17.7% of women in India end up giving up their work in middle management positions

Source: ASSOCHAM, 2007-08

working towards a better society. In Taipei, women have been in the forefront in contributing to public spaces through civic cleanliness drives.

The behavioural differences between the two sexes cannot just be attributed to biology. Environmental circumstances, especially the way they are brought up, are also responsible for such differences. Girls grow up to be nurturers and have a self-sacrificing nature; while boys equate maturity with independence and the denial of

need. As technology compensates for some of the constraints biology imposes on the woman, sharing the responsibility of bringing up children can make the male species more sensitive to others.

The accusation that women usually have narrow horizons and restrict their care and concern only to "others" in their family is a reflection of the narrow identities they are caged in. A larger role and multiple identities will spread the concern.

to 793 in 2001. The all-India average is 933. Development alone is not the answer as sex-selection techniques are used more often among the better off instead of the weaker sections of society. The girl child has to be saved—a feat possible only when "female values" get their due respect. It is only then that a new generation of working women will be born.

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